



Photographs by SIDDHARTHA VAIDYANATHAN

(FROM LEFT) PATEL PITCHES IN A PIRATES GULF COAST LEAGUE GAME; INSIDE THEIR FLORIDA DORMITORY; SINGH WORKS ON HIS FAST BALL

"It's a very difficult game," says Singh. "In cricket fielders can stop concentrating for a little while and still not miss much. Here you have to keep looking out for signals."

The day after they landed they were taken to a college game in Los Angeles by Tom House, pitching coach at the University of Southern California and their baseball guru for the first five months. Their baseball-illiteracy was the least of his worries. House says, "I was really worried that they would injure themselves in the process of learning. And these injuries could even ruin careers. But they were unlike any other kids I've seen because of one simple reason—they weren't scared of failing."

In November, six months after arriving, House took them to Tempe, Arizona where pitchers from around the world converged for the first round of trials. Scouts from all 30 professional teams were on the lookout for talent. Singh and Patel simply treated it like another talent-hunt show. "*Ek ball aur ek bندوق*," says Singh, referring to the speed-gun that was to decide their fate. In the first round neither crossed 87 mph, but in the second, in Los Angeles, Patel's 91-mph (146 kmph) fast ball didn't go un-

noticed. Just as they were beginning to think about returning home—"and joining the army"—the Pirates came shopping. Their one-year contract pays them a stipend of \$1,500 a month and takes care of their stay and travel. It was fitting that the first Indian to break the professional baseball barrier were a Singh and Patel—they are two most common Indian surnames in the US.

So far, they've made up 20 years of lost ground. Now they have to compete with others of their age to move up the baseball's league structure. They have four leagues to wade through before hoping for a Major League spot. They may have learnt to swim; the next few years will be like crossing the English Channel.

It's a precarious existence in the rookie leagues. One poor season is enough for a team to terminate a contract. Considering that the Pirates are one of the lower-ranked teams in the country, it's even more important that the boys don't slip. The novelty of them being the first Indians in pro-baseball will wear out soon; it will then be down to performance.

House is realistic. "I doubt if these guys will reach the 95mph+ (152

kmph) range but some really effective pitchers average between 89 and 93mph (149 kmph). Rinku's left-arm angle will work to his advantage. And Dinesh is likely to be quicker. The crucial years for a pitcher are between 20 and 25. This is their time."

Everyone involved in their remarkable story know what's at stake. A successful baseball career, at any level, could encourage scouts to scour India for more talent. There are 67 pro-leagues in the US, with enough spots for the talented, says Bernstein. "So if people can't make it in cricket in India, they may be tempted to try out baseball here." Back home, their parents and relatives know little about what the boys are up to. But the money is good, far more than they would have earned from throwing the javelin.

Occasionally Singh and Patel think about their childhood dream of hurling towards an Asian Games or Olympic medal. They wonder what they're doing playing an alien sport for a city franchise in a foreign land.

Do they mind that they are not representing India? They look at each other for a few seconds before Singh deadpans: "Doesn't matter, sir. *Naam toh India ka hi hai* (We do represent India after all)."